

# CULTURAL WASTELAND

**In the name of promoting culture the state government spends several crores annually most of which goes into pampering a few favourites**

■ By Farzand Ahmed

**Z**oos in the country which are on the lookout for white elephants need look no further than Jawahar Bhavan in Lucknow for these prize exhibits. Located on its ninth floor is the Uttar Pradesh government's Sanskriti (Culture) Department which runs seven language academies and eight other autonomous institutions. Together the state government spends over Rs 7 crore annually on these 15 "cultural centres", yet not many have an idea of how the money is spent or what goes on inside.

Ask Ashok Ghosh, Principal Secretary-cum-Director who controls the Bhasha and Sanskriti departments (Culture & Language) and he suggests that Additional Director M.L. Paswan answer the questions. Paswan in turn directs all queries to Deputy Director Indu Sinha who simply hands over a copy of the 'performance budget' of the Culture Department and says: "I will not talk to the press unless the government directs me in writing. I won't speak even off the record."

There is a reason. The department controls a number of autonomous bodies of identical nature—Lalit Kala Akademi, Sangeet Natak Akademi, Bharatendu Natya Akademi, Rashtriya Kathak Sansthan and others (see box). The government uses these to accommodate its favourite bureaucrats and political activists. Two months ago the government amended the charter of the Lalit Kala Akademi to replace chairman Umesh Dixit with Ajaysheel Gautam, an artist from Agra and an unabashed supporter of Chief Minister Mayawati. Gautam's energies are now fully devoted to making the Kanshi Ram Jayanti—to commemorate the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) founder's anniversary—a success through exhibitions.



Photograph by MANISH AGARWAL



**FACADE: Lalit Kala Akademi; chairman Gautam (left)**

It is clear that the government is more keen on distributing largesse amongst its faithful. Consider this: on October 3 Tarannum Aqeel, former chairperson of the Muradabad Municipal Corporation was appointed as vice-chairperson of the Uttar Pradesh Urdu Akademi. Aqeel's husband is a minister in Mayawati's cabinet and she too enjoys the status of a minister. "Urdu language is in a bad shape. We have to revive it," she says. Strangely, Urdu Akademi is headed by one Bhavnath Singh, joint-secretary in Bhasha Department, who hardly understands the language. In fact, the Akademi that earlier used to be presided over by well-known writers and poets, has been lifeless for years because of political and bureaucratic interference. It gets an annual grant of Rs 1.15 crore, of which approximately Rs 85 lakh is spent on salaries and other administrative costs.

Similarly, the Allahabad-based Hindustani Akademi is headed by Additional-District Magistrate (ADM) S.K. Pandey, who is known for his efficiency in organising Kumbh melas. This important body was set up to promote Indian languages and was earlier headed by a writer. On the other hand the Ayodhya Shodh Sansthan (Ayodhya Research Institution) was set up at the height of the Ram Mandir

## MONEY FOR NOTHING

### BHASHA DEPARTMENT

|                    |       |
|--------------------|-------|
| Hindustani Akademi | 11.1  |
| UP Hindi Sansthan  | 209.5 |
| Sanskrit Sansthan  | 56.6  |
| UP Urdu Akademi    | 114.6 |
| UP Sindhi Akademi  | 25.4  |
| UP Punjabi Akademi | 1.2   |
| UP Bhasha Sansthan | 77.0  |

### SANSKRITI DEPARTMENT

|                               |      |
|-------------------------------|------|
| Lalit Kala Akademi            | 44.0 |
| Sangeet Natak Akademi         | 92.0 |
| Bharatendu Natya Akademi      | 70.5 |
| Acharya Narendra Deo Sansthan | 10.5 |
| Ayodhya Shodh Sansthan        | 17.0 |
| ST Research Organisation      | 30.0 |
| Rashtriya Kathak Sansthan     | 11.7 |

Figures show government grants in Rs lakh